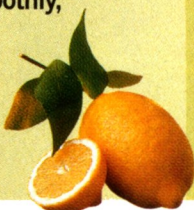


sex up your platter for some gourmet love.

Onion: May smell bad, but increases libido. Peel off the white layer, crush and fry in pure butter. This is an excellent aphrodisiac tonic if taken regularly with a spoon of honey on empty stomach.



Berries, oranges, lemons, kiwi: Antioxidant effects of Vitamin C help protect sex organs, keep them operating smoothly, enhance arousal, sensitivity and orgasm.



Dates: Frequent use of dates is said to be a factor behind the abundant libido in Middle Eastern men. Regular intake of dates soaked in honey, is a libido booster. Excellent source of iron, which strengthens the ovulation process.



genic hormones). Says Raj, "The average age of menopause for Indian women is 44. We have seen a rise in premature ovarian failure due to causes like genetic, drug induced, physiological or because of abuse of ovaries. Women as young as 30 to 35 are suffering from it."

Dr Rishma Dhillon Pai, consultant gynaecologist, Lilavati and Jaslok Hospital says, "I have pa-

tients in their early 20s, 30s and 40s, and sometimes even teenagers, who have attained premature menopause." With almost 10 per cent of women in the reproductive age group suffering from PCOS, specialists like Dr Duru Shah of Gynaeacworld are setting up support groups for patients. "It involves multiple issues and affects various aspects of a woman's life. These patients need to be counselled when they are young," says Dr Sukhpreet Patel, consultant gynaecologist at Bombay Hospital and Gynaecworld.

Indians are also falling prey to booty-banishing problems like obesity and diabetes. Dr Mufazzal Lakdawala, Bariatric Surgeon, Dr L.H. Hiranandani Hospital, Powai says, "The impact of obesity on sex is three fold. It greatly affects a person's body image and social acceptance, which then impacts sexual life. But the most important effect is on fertility levels. About 25 per cent of obese couples are infertile. And as they reach normal weight, they are fine. In some cases, obesity becomes a physical barrier to sex."

While it's a case of scarce time, too many issues for most couples, specialists assure that most cases concerning low libido, erectile dysfunction and infertility are curable. "In the cases of conception problems, only 30 per cent patients actually have a medical problem that can be termed as infertility," explains Raj. So have instances of sexual dysfunctions gravely increased? Or are more cases being detected now than ever before? Doctors and psychiatrists are divided on this one. Says Sinha, "While problems existed even 15 years ago, women were not aware of their sexuality and didn't come out in the open." On the other hand, Shah says in the last five years his patients have quadrupled. "The numbers have definitely increased and people are more willing to come forth and seek treatment," reiterates Shah.

Today, with careening careers, boardroom battles and an alarming lack of sexual knowhow, double-income-no-kids couples are willing to bring their sexual problems from the sanctimonious privacy of their bedrooms to the doctor's clinic. Sex, it seems, is finally coming out of the closet. ■

ently, but those who do have significantly low levels of testosterone may start noticing a decrease in sex drive, a tendency to be grumpy or tired. Worse, they may feel depressed or anxious. This leads doctors to prescribe anti-depressants rather than testosterone replacement drugs. Scientists welcome this attention, saying it is long overdue. It could level the playing field between men and women in the premarital dating game. The message to men is: Wake up. It's not just about women anymore, it's about you, too.

BANDEEP SINGH

problems include tubal blockage due to tuberculosis and endometriosis, according to Parikh. "We also encounter problems with sperm count and motility. Sometimes lack of ovulation or improper ovulation may be the reason for lack of conception," she elaborates. Dr Sushma Sinha, senior consultant, Gynaecology, IVF and Infertility, Indraprastha Apollo Hospital, Delhi says, "Lifestyle changes have impacted men and sperm count has gone down by 50 per cent in the last 50 years also."

While andropause (the male equivalent of menopause) is still a highly-debated topic, other reasons that are cause for concern are reported cases of premature menopause, premature ovarian failure (a stop in the normal functioning of the ovaries in a woman younger than age 40) and increasing cases of polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS) (an endocrine disorder among women of reproductive age, characterised by regular lack of ovulation and excessive amounts of andro-



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sense and simplicity